Women's Specialists of Clear Lake
400 W Medical Center Blvd, Suite 300 · Webster, TX 77598 · (281) 557-0300

Geffrey H. Klein, MD
FACOG · DABOM · Obesity Medicine

Hair Loss While Taking a GLP-1 Medication

What's happening, why it's usually temporary, and what you can do

2.5%
STEP-1 TRIAL RATE
vs 1% on placebo

Some people notice extra shedding or thinning a few weeks to months after starting a GLP-1 medicine. Doctors call this **"telogen effluvium"** — more hairs than usual shift from the growth phase to the resting phase, then fall out. **The follicles stay alive; they just pause.** Rapid weight loss, lower calorie intake, hormonal shifts, and occasional vitamin or mineral gaps all play a role — not the drug itself directly damaging hair.

It's almost always temporary. Because the follicles aren't scarred, new strands usually grow back once the body adjusts. Think of it like autumn leaves falling and spring buds returning. Most cases improve within **6–9 months** after weight stabilizes.

Nutrition

- Hit your protein target — ~1.2 g per kg of ideal body weight daily
- Include iron, zinc, biotin, vitamin D, and B-vitamins each day
- A balanced multivitamin helps if your diet is uneven
- Stay well hydrated — dehydration worsens shedding

Scalp & Hair Care

- Use a gentle shampoo; avoid daily heat styling
- Avoid tight styles that pull on the scalp
- Consider OTC 5% minoxidil foam once daily — can shorten the shedding phase
- Gently massage the scalp for a few minutes daily to boost circulation

Medical Check-Ins

- Review recent labs: thyroid, ferritin, vitamin D, zinc, B12
- Repeat labs if shedding continues past 3 months
- **Do not stop your GLP-1** without medical advice — stopping can cause a second shedding episode from rapid weight regain

When to Call Dr. Klein's Office

- Visible bald spots or patchy hair loss
- Itching or burning of the scalp
- Thyroid symptoms: cold intolerance, constipation, racing heart
- Hair loss continuing longer than 9 months
- Signs of anemia: fatigue, pale skin, shortness of breath
- **(281) 557-0300** · Emergency: 911

KEY TAKEAWAYS

It's the weight loss, not the drug

Mild diffuse shedding is a known response to rapid weight loss — the GLP-1 medication itself isn't directly damaging your hair follicles.

Usually temporary

Most shedding improves within 6–9 months as weight loss slows and nutrition stays solid. The follicles are alive — they will regrow.

Nutrition is your best tool

Good protein, balanced micronutrients, and gentle hair care are the mainstays. A multivitamin and hydration go a long way.

Keep your follow-up visits

Regular labs and individualized tweaks can accelerate regrowth and catch any underlying deficiencies early.